

Scene photo prompts — Macbeth

Nine images, all **16:9**. Save each one under the file name in its heading, in this folder. Nothing else needs doing — the scene picks it up by name.

Prepend this to every prompt

Cinematic film still, 16:9. Eleventh-century Scotland. Dark, atmospheric, painterly realism — the look of a prestige historical film shot on location, not a fantasy poster. Natural light only: cold blue-grey overcast daylight, or warm low firelight. Deep shadows, heavy skies. Muted palette of slate, peat brown and wet stone, deep purple in the shadows, gold only where there is a real flame. Wool, leather, iron, roughspun cloth. No plate armour, no horned helmets, no tartan kilts — wrong century. Shallow depth of field. No text, no lettering, no watermark, no modern objects, no lens flare or glow effects.

And this, wherever Macbeth is in frame (scenes 00, 02, 03, 04, 06, 07, 08):

The man is recognisable by silhouette rather than by face: tall, dark hair, dark beard, a dark red-brown wool cloak. His face is turned away, hooded, in shadow, or at three-quarter profile in low light. Never a clear frontal portrait.

That last rule is doing real work. Image generators will not give you the same face twice, and nine scenes with nine different men breaks the story. Silhouette and colour carry the identity instead — which also happens to suit a play about a man nobody can read.

scene-00-return-from-battle — cover

Wide shot. Two riders crossing a vast empty moor, seen from behind and slightly above, small in the frame. Mud, heather, standing water reflecting a bruised grey sky. Cloaks and horses dirty from a battle that is already over. No castle, no army, no road — just the two of them and the distance. Late afternoon, flat cold light, rain not yet falling.

scene-01-three-witches — the heath

Three cloaked figures standing close together in low mist on open moorland, facing the camera with their faces lost inside their hoods. Ragged dark wool, wind pulling at the hems. Behind them the moor dissolves into fog. At the edge of the frame, out of focus, the shoulder and reins of a horse that has stopped. Grey-green, damp, unnervingly still. No cauldron, no fire, no green light, no pointed hats.

scene-02-thane-of-cawdor — the messenger

A king's messenger on a muddy road handing a sealed letter up to a mounted soldier who leans down to take it. Both in wet wool cloaks; the messenger's horse steaming from a hard ride. Bare hills behind, cold overcast light. The paper and its red wax seal are the brightest things in the frame.

scene-03-forres-court — the king names his heir

Interior of a great stone hall lit by torches and one high window. An older king in a fur-lined cloak stands on a raised step, a hand on the shoulder of a young man beside him, presenting him to the room. In the middle ground a crowd of thanes watching — and among them one man standing very slightly apart, half turned away. Long shadows, smoke in the air, gold firelight on stone. Formal, public, watched.

scene-04-the-aside — the private thought

A man in a dark red-brown cloak standing just outside the pool of light from a hall full of people, back three-quarters to the camera. Behind him, out of focus, the warm blur of the court still talking; the stone wall beside him is cold blue. Tight framing, shallow depth of field, the composition split between the bright company and the dark man. Private thought made visible.

scene-05-duncan-arrives — Inverness at dusk

A castle gate at dusk seen from inside the courtyard. Riders coming through the arch, torches being lit along the wall, servants on the steps. Last blue light in the sky above the battlements, warm orange fire below. Birds settling on the walls. Welcoming, and slightly too quiet. Wide establishing shot.

scene-06-lady-macbeth — the corridor

A narrow dark stone corridor at night. A woman in a long dark gown holds a single candle close to her chest, speaking with quiet intensity to a man facing her, his back to the camera. The candle is the only light in the shot — it lights her face from below and leaves everything past two metres in blackness. Intimate, conspiratorial, claustrophobic. Tight framing.

scene-07-ending-duncan-dies — the crown

A crowned man sitting alone on a throne in a vast empty stone hall, small in a wide frame. He leans forward, hands together, looking at nothing. Cold grey light from a high window catches him from one side; the rest of the hall is dark. No courtiers, no guards, no banners. The crown catches a little light and nothing else does. Stillness, and the wrong kind of quiet.

scene-08-ending-duncan-lives — the morning

First light. A man alone on a castle wall, seen from behind, watching a column of riders move away along a road far below through morning mist. Pale gold on the horizon, the valley still blue with shadow, his cloak moving in the wind. Wide shot, the figure small against a large landscape. Calm, open, and unresolved.